

Digital Services Act

Transparency Report for start.gg and GroupMe

February 2025

Introduction

This DSA Transparency Report addresses the services provided by start.gg, a platform for esports communities used to host, discover, and participate in esports tournaments. start.gg has an average of 7,641 users per month in the EU. This DSA Transparency Report further covers GroupMe, a consumer communications product used by consumers for communications purposes on mobile and via webapp, that has an average of 180,000 users per month in the EU.

This DSA Transparency Report is responsive to the obligations under DSA Article 15(1), Article 24(1), and Article 42(2)-(3). This Report provides information regarding the following topics as they pertain to the European Union:

- Content Moderation at Microsoft's Initiative
- Content Moderation & Automated Systems
- Content Moderation following a User Report
- Content Moderation Appeals
- Government Requests
- Out of Court Settlement Body Dispute

Note: Microsoft Corporation sold to Startgg, Inc., a Delaware corporation, assets related to the platform and business start.gg (<https://www.start.gg/>) in a transaction that closed on January 29, 2025. The buyer plans to continue to operate the business after closing.

Content Moderation at Microsoft's Initiative

Microsoft provides the information below in response to DSA Article 15(1)(c). This section reports data regarding content moderation start.gg and GroupMe engaged in on their own initiative, absent a user report.

This section describes activities start.gg and GroupMe undertake at its own initiative to address illegal content or information in violation of their terms and conditions, which can be found [Microsoft Services Agreement](#).

start.gg prohibits harassment on its site. Users can report harassment to help@start.gg. Users in the EU may also send notices of content that is allegedly illegal to legal@start.gg. Events, users, and tournaments may be removed at the discretion of start.gg. Violation of the harassment policy may result in account suspension or deletion.

start.gg also has proactive moderation for offensive terms and hate speech in fields that generate publicly viewable data such as user-facing gamertags and names, discussed in more detail in Content Moderation & Automated Systems.

GroupMe prohibits abusive and violating content. A user can report a message, a contact, or a group for abuse. The reporter can select the type of concern and add any additional details about the offensive behavior. The process is available in the app and is explained to users on the GroupMe support page. [How do I report abuse in GroupMe? - Microsoft Support](#)

When start.gg and GroupMe receive content moderation reports, the report is submitted to an internal Microsoft moderation team that manages a centralized content moderation reporting system across multiple Microsoft products. Reports contain the content owner information and report details. Reports are reviewed by this centralized team, which then advises start.gg and GroupMe on what action to take with respect to any content or listing. The content owner is provided with a process to appeal if their content is removed.

Violating content is blocked from sharing or is removed, and, in the case of egregious violations such as sharing child sexual abuse material, the account of the content owner may also be terminated in accordance with Microsoft's published policies.

Content Moderation & Automated Systems

Microsoft provides the information below in response to DSA Articles 15(1)(e) and 42(2)(c).

start.gg uses text matching to moderate content. Text matching prevents users from submitting text containing offensive terms or hate speech. It prevents users from using gamertags, team names, and tournament descriptions that contain offensive terms and hate speech. Users who submit text that contain these types of terms must revise and resubmit their text before it can be saved.

Because this system does not permit users to save submissions with offensive terms or hate speech, there is no data on the number of times users have submitted offensive terms or hate speech.

GroupMe is in the process of onboarding onto automated content detection for all image/photo content that is uploaded within communication threads. GroupMe will leverage automated content detection to detect known child sexual abuse material (CSAM) and terrorist content using both PhotoDNA and MD5 hashes.

PhotoDNA is a perceptual hashing technology, which is used to identify visually identical and near identical images and video. To do so, PhotoDNA creates a unique digital signature (known as a “hash”) of an image or selected frames in a video and compares it against signatures (“hashes”) of previously identified CSAM and terrorist content images or video. PhotoDNA is not facial recognition software and cannot be used to identify a person or object in an image.

	GroupMe
Number of measures not taken by automated means	7

Content Moderation following a User Report

Microsoft provides the information below in response to DSA Articles 15(1)(b)-(c) and 41(2)(a)-(b).

start.gg did not receive any user reports during the Reporting Period.

Product Data, respectively: GroupMe

Policy Violation	Number of notices received	Number of specific items of information included in the total number of notices	Median time to take action	Number of actions taken on the basis of the terms and conditions of the service
Illegal or Harmful Speech	1	1		
IP Infringements	420	420		
Nonconsensual Behaviour	634	634	1.0	1
Pornography or Sexualized Content	3	3		
Protection of Minors	392	392		
Risk for public security	391	391		
Scams and Fraud	1,131	1,131		

Scope of Platform Services	336	336	2.2	6
Self Harm	205	205		

Content Moderation Appeals

Microsoft provides the information below in response to DSA Article 15(1)(d)

start.gg did not receive notice of any content moderation appeals during the Reporting Period.

	GroupMe
Number of complaints submitted to the internal-complaints mechanism	5.0

Government Requests

Microsoft provides the information below in response to DSA Article 15(1)(a)

start.gg and GroupMe did not receive notice of any government requests to remove content during the Reporting Period.

Out of Court Settlement Body Disputes

Microsoft provides the information below in response to DSA Article 24(1)(a).

start.gg and GroupMe did not receive notice of any disputes submitted to an out-of-court dispute settlement bodies during the reporting period.